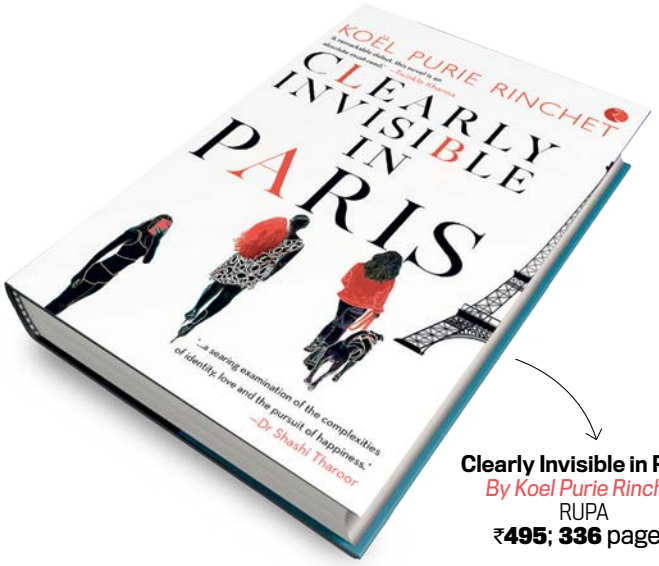
City of Light and Dark

BOOKS

Beneath the swagger of Koel Purie Rinchet's impressive debut novel lies a serious story



Clearly Invisible in Paris
By Koel Purie Rinchet
RUPA
₹**495**; **336** pages



Koel Purie Rinchet's debut novel *Clearly Invisible in Paris* begins on a supremely confident note, introducing us to its four principal characters via 'point-of-view' chapters, the literary equivalent of a 'split-screen' device in cinema. Teenaged Russian model Dasha cannot stop herself from showing the finger to the exploitative overlords of the fashion world, even if it stops her march to the big leagues. Filipina housekeeper (and later, nanny) Rosel is desperate to be reunited with her infant son, but her passport and documents have been confiscated by her conniving ex-employers. Senegalese trans woman Violet struggles with her job as a burlesque dancer, her memories of pre-transition life, and her feelings for Raphael, a handsome beggar she finds herself drawn to. And finally, beautiful, ennui-riddled columnist Neera, married to a handsome, older French filmmaker-producer, burying herself in plumes of marijuana smoke and ill-advised trysts with strangers.

Clearly Invisible in Paris is the fun-loving, briskly moving story of these four women connected by circumstances and the same apartment building. It's a lot of fun watching Neera and Co. laugh and cry with each other, support each other through adversity and generally fumble their way through their unlikely bond. But there are also moments of genuine dramatic heft in their journey and, to the author's credit, these are handled deftly and with compassion. Rinchet has the ability to be serious without sounding sombre on the page, which isn't something you can teach.

I found Neera to be a particularly compelling character, not just because of the layered portrayal; all four characters get richly imagined pasts, after all, unfurled gradually across the book (we learn, for example, that the Rodrigo Duterte government in the Philippines was responsible for the murders of Rosel's brother and her partner). Drama has a funny way of following Neera—she meets her future husband at a dinner party where an angry wife smashes a bottle of Dom Pérignon over her head, outraged at her husband impulsively kissing Neera on the dance floor. She meets Dasha and Violet when she's hanging mid-air, several floors above the ground, restrained by nothing more than knotted-up bedsheets. Her fading sense of self, she realises, cannot be remedied by the endless joints she smokes. But as an effective defence mechanism, she finds them irresistible; a realistic and empathetic point-of-view that does not treat addicts as the problem. "Suddenly, she craved the compassionate cloud of a joint, under whose brume she could listen till there were no more stories left to hear. High, she was present mentally and physically without actually having to be present emotionally. She engaged without being invested. It was a comfortable place. A womb."

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Throughout the novel, there are 'small miracles', moments of brief, cathartic joy that punctuate the very different lives led by these four women; Rosel, for example, enjoys the sudden shock of hearing bursts of Tagalog among Filipino migrants in Paris. Dasha rejoices at her whip-smart brother's academic achievements. Rinchet imbues these moments with a dignity that also underlines one of the book's central concerns—dislocation, the thousand and one ruptures and fractures that mark the migrant life. *Clearly Invisible in Paris* is a sure-footed debut novel that will leave you wanting to spend more time with its remarkable protagonists. ■

Aditya Mani Jha